

ANTHROPOLOGICAL MISCELLANEA.

REGRESSION *towards* MEDIOCRITY *in* HEREDITARY STATURE.

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[WITH PLATES IX AND X.]

THIS memoir contains the data upon which the remarks on the Law of Regression were founded, that I made in my Presidential Address to Section H, at Aberdeen. That address, which will appear in due course in the Journal of the British Association, has already been published in "Nature," September 24th. I reproduce here the portion of it which bears upon regression, together with some amplification where brevity had rendered it obscure, and I have added copies of the diagrams suspended at the meeting, without which the letterpress is necessarily difficult to follow. My object is to place beyond doubt the existence of a simple and far-reaching law that governs the hereditary transmission of, I believe, every one of those simple qualities which all possess, though in unequal degrees. I once before ventured to draw attention to this law on far more slender evidence than I now possess.

It is some years since I made an extensive series of experiments on the produce of seeds of different size but of the same species. They yielded results that seemed very noteworthy, and I used them as the basis of a lecture before the Royal Institution on February 9th, 1877. It appeared from these experiments that the offspring did *not* tend to resemble their parent seeds in size, but to be always more mediocre than they—to be smaller than the parents, if the parents were large; to be larger than the parents, if the parents were very small. The point of convergence was considerably below the average size of the seeds contained in the large bagful I bought at a nursery garden, out of which I selected those that were sown